

Some craftsmen put the seals of their names on the porcelains they made, an exclusive phenomenon in the late Qing Dynasty, such as the seals of Zhao Zhiqian (趙之謙), Chen Guozhi (陳國治), Wang Bingrong (王炳榮) and Li Yuyuan (李裕元). They were craftsmen after Daoguang Reign.

Since Jiaqing Reign, seals of the names of various halls and workshops began to gain popularity, exerting great influence on the seals in the following reigns. Such seals were put on the porcelain stationery, the sacrificial utensils and the tableware. Every reign had its own representative seals, such as the seals of Hall of Yuqing (玉慶堂), Hall of Qingyi (慶宜堂), Hall of Diligence (懋勤殿), Hall of Caihua (彩華堂), Runbi Veranda (潤碧軒) and the Building of River on a Spring Night (春江花月樓) in Jiaqing Reign; the seals of Hall of Hangyouhuan (行有垣堂), Hall of Prudent Morality (慎德堂), Hall of Ten Inkstone (十硯齋), Hall of Storing Classic Books (經筵堂), Hall of Double Purenness (雙清閣), Villa of Crescent Moon (桂月山莊), Veranda of Ancient Moon (古月軒), Ningjin Hall (寧晉齋), Zhuyunshan House (竹韻山房), Study of Heavenly Fragrance (天香書屋), Wanyan Ancestral Temple (完顏宗祠) and Huifu Temple (慧福寺) in Daoguang Reign; the seal of Hall of Seclusion and Meditation (退思堂) in the Xianfeng Reign; the seals of Hall of Manifest Harmony (體和殿), Hall of Happy Spring (樂春堂), Hall of Rule (治堂) in Tongzhi Reign; the seals of Hall of Great Elegance (大雅齋), Hall of Preserved Elegance (儲秀宮), Yishan Hall (一善堂) in Guangxu Reign; and the seals of Chinese Treasure Hall (清華珍品), Hall of Earthly Tranquillity (坤寧宮) and Yishou Hall (宜壽堂) in Xuantong Reign.

Seals of auspicious words appeared on the porcelains used for weddings and other festival celebrations. For example, the porcelains with seals of "the happiness in wedding (燕喜同和)" were produced specially of the wedding of Emperor Tongzhi. The porcelains with an oval seal of "universal spring (天地一家春)" in red official script of calligraphy together with a seal of Hall of Great Elegance (大雅齋) were made for specially for Cixi. There were also some other seals carrying Chinese characters meaning "eternal happiness and everlasting spring (永慶長春, 長春同慶)," "high mountains and long rivers (山高水長)," "happiness and auspices (吉祥如意)," "enjoy emolument forever (食祿萬鏡)" and "successful in imperial examination (狀元及第)." Besides, seals of one-character auspicious words meaning fortune (福), longevity (壽), happiness (喜) and nobleness (貴) respectively as well as seals of "country in safety for a thousand years (千歲夫國安)" in the Taiping Heavenly Kingdom Reign were all very popular in the late Qing Dynasty.

There were also seals indicating the name of the owners of the porcelains, such as the seal of "Wanyan (完顏氏)" on the Jiaqing *Qinghua* plate with lined lotus pattern, the seal of "Zhengzhai Master (正齋主人)" on the Daoguang *Fencai* jar with pattern of bamboo and chrysanthemum, the seal of "Wang Bingrong (王炳榮)" on the Tongzhi *Fencai* round case with relief bat and peach pattern on yellow ground, and the seal of "the treasured porcelain owned by the master of Xueyuan Hall (雪源小隱主人珍玩)" on the Guangxu *Fencai* cricket jar. Such seals were also called seals of "private uses." Many porcelains with such seals also bear Chinese characters beside the seals or on other parts of the ware meaning "treasure collection (珍藏)," "treasured porcelain (珍玩)," "delicately made (雅制)," "treasured jade (玩玉)" and "perceived happiness (知樂)," etc.

Since Jiaqing Reign, apart from *Qinghua*, red, gold and ink colours were applied to the writing of seals on porcelains. There were also some signeted ones. In terms of calligraphic styles, the seal script was more commonly adopted than the official script in the Jiaqing and Daoguang reigns. Beginning from the Xianfeng Reign, the regular character became very popular. Seals on porcelains made in Imperial Factory consist mostly of four or six Chinese characters written regularly and clearly in two vertical lines, of six Chinese characters written in three horizontal lines, or partly written in one horizontal line. Seals on civil-kiln-made porcelain, on the other hand, were often randomly written or half-written characters.

In the 29th year of Guangxu Reign (AD 1903), the Jingdezhen Porcelain Company, the first official and private porcelain joint venture, was founded, which was presided by Mr Sun Tinglin. It was one of the seven porcelain enterprises set up between the 30th year of Guangxu Reign and the second year of Xuantong Reign (AD 1904 -- 1910), with an assets of 55,000 yuan. Its name was changed into Jiangxi Porcelain Company after it became completely private-owned and its assets later grew to some 200,000 yuan. In the meantime, it adopted machine production and the advanced techniques. The company integrated production with sale by setting up sales offices in Shanghai, Nanchang and Jiujiang, generating great profits. It was said that its products could match those made in Imperial Factory in the early Qing Dynasty. Its products were awarded gold medals at the Belgian World Fair in the second year of Xuantong Reign (AD 1910), the French World Fair in the third year of Xuantong Reign (AD 1911) at the Japanese Fair in 1914, and the American Panama Fair in 1915. Therefore, some foreign experts refuted the allegation that the late Qing Dynasty witnessed setbacks in the technological levels of Jingdezhen craftsmen and the quality of porcelain